Gandhi?'[6]) This means that, although the BJP has gained politically from the wider work of RSS workers, it does not control them. It is true that the party has focused on building its own cadres from the day it was born, but its network was not robust enough and widespread enough at the mohalla (street) level in large swathes of India until the early 2000s. So, for decades, it remained deeply dependent on Sangh cadres for voter mobilisation during elections—a situation that had its own pitfalls.

This is why the BJP's Rajya Sabha MP Swapan Dasgupta rightly argued in 2009 that 'One of the enduring political myths of India is the belief that, like the Communist Party of India (Marxist), the Bharatiya Janata Party is a cadre-based outfit. This misconception, spread assiduously by both the media and professional saffron watchers in academia who bank on press clippings as primary source material, is centred on the assumption that the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh is the BJP's dedicated volunteer army. Consequently, the BJP is expected to replicate the disciplined drill of the RSS. When it fails to do so—and the failures are becoming more and more apparent—the party is judged far more harshly than, say, the Congress whose projected image as a big umbrella party has outlived its degeneration into a dynastic outfit.'[7]

Dasgupta's deeper point was that the BJP's party workers, while mostly on the same ideological wavelength, were not as uniformly controlled and the party's organisational structure was not as efficient as that of the RSS. Moreover, the BJP's election ground game in many parts of the country was not dissimilar in structure and efficiency (or inefficiency) to that of other political parties. As has been shown by several scholars of the Sangh as well as the Hindu nationalist movement, for years, the post of organisational secretary (later, sangathan mantri) was key to the office-level work of the party. This was as true of the BJP in 1980 as it was of its predecessor, the Bharatiya Jan Sangh, in the pre-1977 period.[8] Early Jan Sangh leaders from the RSS, like Nanaji Deshmukh, who played a key role in forging anti-Congress alliances with other Opposition parties in 1967, and Sundar Singh Bhandari, exemplified the crossover into the party for key organisational roles in the 1960s and 1970s. But after the BJP led an alliance government in New Delhi from 1998 to 2004